Balance and Voiding (v0.1.0.)

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This document is an elaboration on materials and principles taught over the course of several classes at *Klingenspiel* in Vienna. The focus of these lessons were on ways of actively using balance to prepare and initiate actions, especially voids. To make that possible, however, a fencer must be able to control and manipulate their balance, both in the guard and in transitory and preparatory positions. For many fencers, however, balance is an afterthought. For that reason, the first section of this document contains drills and exercises to develop an awareness of balance in various positions and movements. The second section combines these movements in a number of simple drills and partner drills. The third and final section contains two partner drills that gradually build from simple action/reaction to something resembling constrained sparring.

A Note on Drilling

Start slow, then get faster until you are at or close to sparring speed. Live at 80–100%.

1. Fundamentals

What is balance?

Guard

TK Throughout TK, come back to your guard and adjust it.

Balance/out of balance

First standing, then from guard

Drop step

Rory Miller

Altered drop step

Shift weight and lean, then drop-step

Lunge

Arm, lean/shift, catch. Do not push off back foot.

Traverso R

As lunge, but different direction

Traverso L

As trav R, but to the other side. Leave blade in place.

Passata

As lunge + trav L.

Passata Sotto

Shift weight back, then drop step

Back lunge

Shift weight back with a turn, then as lunge.

Volte/Incartata/Scanzo

Shift weight, then 'throw' shoulder.

Gathering Step

Different ways of finishing—as a regular step, or any of the movements above.

2. Simple Drills

TK. These drills work regardless of whether both fencers hold their weapon in the same hand or not.

On Cue

On Cue with Steps

Stick I

Stick II

Stick III

Bind I–III

3. Complex Drills

Each of the following drills is made up of a series of steps and are designed to be practised progressively—first step one, once that works at full speed, step one and two, then one and two and three, etc. Start each iteration slower than you think and speed it up to something like sparring speed over 4–8 repetitions.

The goal of each action is to hit the opponent while not getting hit, but it is not the goal of the drill to win at all costs. Each action should counter the previous action, but especially as speed and intensity increase, not every action will be successful. That is fine. Analyse what went wrong and try again. As with the simple drills, focus on balance and on using it to initiate each action.

These drills encourages a style of fencing that emphasises control over explosiveness. Control does not mean strength, however. A weaker fencer with good structure and good technique (strong on weak, etc.) has little issue controlling a much stronger fencer. Nonetheless, fencers who have based their style on being faster than their opponents may find it frustrating.

3.1. First Drill

Fencers (A and B) start in middle distance (where either can hit the other with a lunge).

1. A binds onto B's blade on the inside or outside; B disengages; A rebinds. On a disengage of their choice, A lunges, striking B with a thrust in opposition instead of rebinding.
2. If A attacks on the inside, B voids with a volte or scanzo; if A attacks on the outside, B voids with a traverso L. In either case, B 'leaves' their blade in the middle line, as described in section 1 above.
3. A parries B's blade with their empty hand, and strikes B with a stramazone to the head. The stramazone can be done with or without a step of the back foot.

3.2. Second Drill

Fencers start at a distance where either can strike the other with a gathering step and a lunge.

1. A binds onto B's blade on the inside or outside with a gathering step; B disengages and lunges, striking A with a thrust in opposition.
2. If B attacks on the inside, A voids with a volte or scanzo; if B attacks on the outside, A voids with a traverso L. In either case, A 'leaves' their blade in the middle line, as described in section 1 above.
3. As 2 above, but instead of disengaging and striking, B may instead take a step backwards. If they do, A finishes the gathering step as a step forward, effectively resetting the situation.
4. As 3 above, but from the initial position, either fencer may initiate the action with a gathering step. At this point, this drill begins to resemble a constrained for of sparring, and the intensity should eventually reflect that.

3.3. Third Drill

This drill combines elements of the two drills above. Fencers start at a distance where either can strike the other with a gathering step and a lunge.

1. A binds onto B's blade on the inside or outside with a gathering step; B disengages and lunges, striking A with a thrust in opposition.
2. A either takes B's disengage as a tempo to strike them with a thrust in opposition,[1] or voids B's attack with a volte/scanzo or traverso L, depending on whether B attacks on the inside or the outside.
3. If A attacks into B's disengage, B voids A's attack with a volte/scanzo or traverso L.
4. If B voids, A parries B's blade with their empty hand, and strikes B with a stramazone to the head. The stramazone can be done with or without a step of the back foot. If A voids, B parries with the empty hand, etc.

[1] Depending on the style of both fencers involved, this thrust may or may not need a lunge to hit. Most analogous actions from historical treatises include a lunge, likely because it allows you to get past the opponents point. As that is not possible with sparring weapons, a lunge may not be practical, but in any case, A should step slightly off-line with their attack.

5. Instead of disengaging and striking when a seeks the bind, B may take a step backwards. If they do, A finishes the gathering step as a step forward, effectively resetting the situation.
6. As 5 above, but from the initial position, either fencer may initiate the action by seeking the bind with a gathering step. Adding this step makes for an extremely complex drill and in most cases it is best left out.

3.4. Improvising Drills

Once two fencers have repertoire of actions and are comfortable moving within the idiom of their style (whether that is as broad as 'seventeenth-century Italian rapier' or as narrow as 'Rapier after Capo Ferro'), they can begin to improvise drills like the ones above. Doing so is a great awareness drill, and can be tailored to reinforce a fencer's strength or to address their weaknesses. Drills like these can also given a focus other than balance, e.g. moving off line, using the empty hand, blade-foot coordination, etc. I have found the following guidelines to be helpful:

- Agree on a starting distance and action, e.g. a beat and a thrust, seeking a bind, etc. The drills above are ambidextrous and symmetrical, but that is not a requirement.
- Each iteration of the drill should be done slowly and then sped up over 4–8 repetitions.
- Regardless of the speed, every action should be done with full force aiming at good targets.
- Try to keep each 'turn' to one or, at most, two actions each.
- Each action after the first should be what Rory Miller calls a *golden move* (Miller 2016): it protects you, hurts your opponent, puts you in a better position, puts your opponent in a worse position.
- Keep the exchanges relatively short (2–5 'turns' at most), otherwise what started as a fencing drill becomes a memory game.

References

Capo Ferro, Ridolfo. n.d. 'Ridolfo Capo Ferro Da Cagli'. Translated by William Wilson and W. Jherek Swanger. Accessed 10 June 2024. https://wiktenauer.com/wiki/Ridolfo_Capo_Ferro_da_Cagli.

Miller, Rory. 2016. *Training for Sudden Violence: 72 Practical Drills*. YMAA Publication Center.